Modals: should, must, may, might

Goal: To use the modal verbs *should*, *must*, *may* and *might* correctly to give advice, express obligation and necessity, ask permission and talk about possibility when discussing hopes and ambitions.

The idea in two lines: Modals are helping verbs that add a meaning (advice, obligation, possibility, permission) to the main verb. They never change form and are always followed by the base verb without *to*.

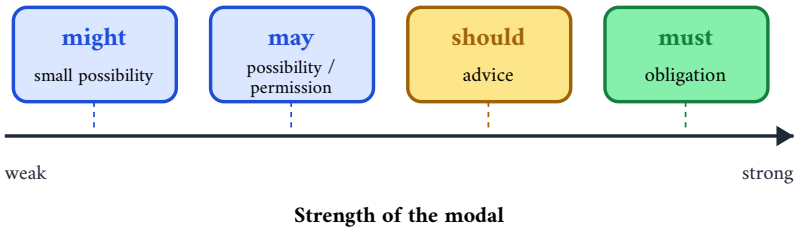


Figure 1: From a small possibility (might) to a strong obligation (must); should is a recommendation in between.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **General form:** subject + modal + base verb (*You should sleep early*). No *-s* with he/she/it, no *to*, no *do* in questions and negatives: *Should I go? / You mustn't shout.*
2. **should / shouldn't:** advice and recommendation. *You should revise your lessons. You shouldn't waste time.*
3. **must:** strong obligation or necessity, often from the speaker or a rule. *Pupils must respect the school rules.* **mustn't** = prohibition: *You mustn't cheat in the exam.*
4. **may:** possibility or polite permission. *It may snow tonight. May I come in?*
5. **might:** a weaker possibility, less sure than *may*. *I might become an engineer, I'm not sure yet.*
6. In the future, *must* is replaced by *will have to*; in the past by *had to*.

7. **Short answers:** *Should I call him? – Yes, you should. / May I leave? – Yes, you may.*

🟢 Examples

1. Choose the right modal: *Drivers ..... stop at the red light.* **Solution:** Drivers **must** stop at the red light. **Explanation:** this is a law, a strong obligation.
2. *Nadia wants to become a pilot. Give her advice.* **Solution:** She **should** study maths and physics seriously, and she **shouldn't** give up her dream.
3. *Will Amine join the trip?* (he is not sure) **Solution:** He **might** join us, but he hasn't decided yet. **Explanation:** *might* shows an uncertain possibility.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Adding *to*: *You must to go* ✕ → *You must go* ✓.
- Adding *-s*: *She shoulds* ✕; *He musts* ✕.
- Confusing *mustn't* (prohibition) with *don't have to* (no obligation): *You don't have to come* = it is not necessary.
- Using *do* in questions: *Do you should...?* ✕ → *Should you...?* ✓.

🟡 Quick review

- Modal + base verb, no -s, no to, no do.
- should = advice; must = obligation; mustn't = prohibition.
- may = possibility or permission; might = weaker possibility.
- Past of must = had to; future = will have to.
- Question: modal + subject + verb (*May I...?*).

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